kept his back to her. He thought he knew her better than she knew herself, but she would prove him wrong. She stepped forward, the first step of many in this new life, and touched his shoulder.

“I will be a good wife to you in exchange for the nineteen Russian women and my sister, André and Josef.”

He turned around, his face red and eyes big. “Round it up to twenty since there’s an unborn child,” he said sharply.

“I will marry you,” she repeated, lifting the ring out of the box. “I will carry this in my pocket and then put it on my finger after the war, staying here and being the good wife you want. In exchange, you will save all the Russian women, my sister, André and Josef.” She held out her hand. “Do you agree?”

He threw the pipe on the wooden desk. It rolled off the edge and fell to the ground. Why did he hesitate? Did he not have the power to help Léa and the others escape?

No, his skill was tracking people—where they went, whom they spoke to, what they said. He knew things she could never know. His contacts were extensive. The only way for Léa and the others to get out before the Soviet army arrived—everyone said they were months away and the fact that he had made her this offer tonight meant the rumors could be true—was if Reinhardt arranged it. The question was whether he wanted her enough to do it. She would make him. He was wrong about her. She knew herself better than he did. She stepped closer, placing her other hand on his face, waiting. A few moments passed, then she felt his grip firm and solid against her hand.

“Agreed,” he said.

She dropped the ring in her apron pocket and left.